



Climbing is physically, mentally, and emotionally demanding — and that’s exactly why climbers love, live, and breathe it

Breath is not just a background process in climbing—it reflects effort, emotion, attention, intention, and recovery, in every moment on the rock.

Wolfgang Güllich embodied the spirit of progression and creativity, blending vision, strength, and innovation to elevate climbing into a new dimension of movement and possibility. Güllich highlighted how climbing is more than just a sport—it’s a way of life:

“You don’t go for coffee after climbing; rather, going out for coffee is part climbing.”₁

An inner fire burns bright in a climber who loves climbing: passion, power, intensity, flowing energy, and high motivation, come and go. These shifts in energy are not just emotional—they are physiological, often mirrored in changes in breathing rhythm and depth.

Steph Davis is one of the world’s leading climbers, known for her

ground breaking free solo ascents, big wall achievements, and fearless exploration of climbing and human flight. Steph captures the essence of climbing:

“Climbing, I believe, is simply about love, and this kind of love grows.”₂

A love of climbing involves freedom, adventure, and exploration; curiosity, courage, high energy, efficient movement, and peak flow states of consciousness. It also involves discomfort — pushing through with grit, hardiness, and resilience — and tolerating pain. In these moments, breathing often becomes strained or irregular — yet learning to stay with the breath can stabilise both body and mind.

Climbing outdoors lifts one’s spirit — we are deeply connected to nature through our breath. Each breath becomes an exchange between body and environment, linking internal state with the external world. Breathwork helps regulate energy flow through the body, expanding resilience and enabling faster adaptation. Loving climbing creates less resistance. Love motivates.

Tommy Caldwell is a legendary big wall climber whose resilience and

long-term dedication redefined what is possible on the world’s hardest rock faces. Tommy says:

“On the wall it’s like I come alive; this place changes me. It always has. I take a deep breath and turn to the sheer face rising above.”₃

We must see in our mind’s eye and feel the climb we expect to send

Johnny Dawes embodies imagination, flow, and fearless vision—using movement, rhythm, and intuition to turn impossible lines into reality.

In 1986, his imagination—almost fantasy—and deep love for climbing, art, and nature pushed British climbing into a new era. The bold and uncompromising line of Indian Face made his heart race. Johnny held a clear inner vision, supported by a remarkable ability to visualise and feel the climb before it was ever realised. His ascent established the first E9.

His feelings were clear:

“Nobody had bolted it. It was just this sheet of tiny, impenetrable link-ups between poor holds. It looked really futuristic. It absolutely made your heart race, and was beautiful.”₄

Steve McClure reflects in his autobiography *Beyond Limits* on the deeper essence of why he climbs. His journey is not just about

performance, but about returning to something more fundamental — pure love for movement and experience. The Kindle description captures this beautifully:

“As he searches for what really makes him tick, his climbing comes full circle and returns to where it started — climbing for the love of it.”₅

This pure love for climbing resonates with many, including Stevie Haston, who vividly recalls the raw experiences that ignited his passion:

“At 16, I climbed the Col du Plan Direct (M4) in Chamonix during winter in jeans with a pair of long johns underneath. It taught me I was weak, had shit gear and knew nothing. I loved it and wanted more.”₆

Both climbers remind us that, at its core, climbing is about fun, passion, discovery, and an enduring love for the challenge.

Our mental state is intentional when it is directed at a clear, external focus of attention

A mental state—thought, belief, desire, fear, or doubt—is intentional when it is directed toward an object, scenario, or goal, even if that target does not yet exist:

“For a mental state to be intentional is for it to be about, or directed at, something.”₇

Like an arrow shot toward a target, the arrow (your thought) is aimed at a mark—your object, your goal, your vision. Olympic gold medallist Janja Garnbret offers a real-world example of this:

“The thought means a lot. I was not scared to dream big.”⁸

Here, Janja’s mind forms a thought about a future aspiration — she is intentionally directing her mental state toward that goal.

Love is one of the most powerful intentional states we experience. It is directed outward — to a person, an activity, or a way of being. In climbing, love is not just a feeling; it is the energy that sustains volition and makes commitment joyful rather than forced.

Janja is clear:

“I just want to climb. I’m in love with climbing and I just enjoy what I’m doing.”⁹

Janja embodies precision, dominance, and effortless flow — combining joy, focus, and fearless ambition.

Martina Demmel represents rapid progression and elite onsight ability—rising to 9a level within just a few years of climbing. She describes her approach simply:

“I’ve in my mind and for sure to always do it just because I truly love it.”¹⁰

Her intentional state defines her onsight style: full engagement, no resistance, and a willingness to step into the unknown:

“I truly love to just climb into the unknown...”¹¹

Magnus Midtbø echoes the same intentionality, rooted in love and freedom. His connection to climbing is simple, direct, and deeply felt:

“I just love climbing. I love being in the nature. I love the feeling of feeling free.....”¹²

For Magnus, climbing is not just performance—it is expression. A space where movement, nature, and breath come together, creating a sense of freedom that fuels both motivation and longevity in the sport.

For Adam Ondra, one of the greatest sport climbers in the world, intentionality fuels passion across extraordinary achievements—from Silence (9c) to Super Crackinette (9a+ flash). What drives him is not just the grade, but the joy and sensation of the experience itself:

“I love being out there and feeling the air below my feet..... How it feels to be so fit and flow up those routes—it’s addictive”¹³

For Adam, climbing is a state of total engagement—where effort, movement, and breath merge into flow, and performance becomes an expression of pure love for the climb.

Tommy Caldwell, reflecting on his life-defining project on the Dawn Wall, captures how love as an intentional state extends far beyond the climb itself:

“I love the way the Dawn Wall breathes energy into my entire life.”¹⁴

For him, climbing is not just an act—it is a source of energy, meaning, and transformation.

Love is not passive. It is an intentional act—radiating outward from within us toward whatever we choose to focus on. It sustains us through effort and directs us toward what matters most.

As John Lennon once said:

“Love is the flower you’ve got to let grow.”¹⁵

Love feels like a strong emotion and is widely regarded as one. However, psychobiology says it is not

Love is one of the most powerful intentional states we experience. Love is often described as a powerful emotion, yet psychobiology suggests it is a drive—an enduring state that motivates behaviour:

“Love is usually accompanied by the most intensive emotions, but love is not an emotion.”¹⁶

Rather, it is:

“an intricate pattern of potential thoughts, behaviours and emotions that tend to run together.”¹⁷

Emotions such as fear, surprise, joy, elation, anger, or anxiety are transient—they come and go like passing winds. Love, by contrast, endures. It persists as an intentional state—a directed force that makes us stronger and more resilient. We learn to feel all our emotions as energy—and through breath, we can move, guide, and transform that energy.

As the poet Rumi reflects:

“Love is not an emotion, it’s your very existence.”¹⁸

Climbers often describe their connection to the sport as a deep, enduring drive. Sasha DiGiulian expresses this instantly:

“If I were to believe in love at first sight, climbing would be the supporting evidence.”¹⁹

Yet this love is sustained over time. Her first female free ascent of the Platinum Wall on El Capitan — after years of effort and a 23-day push — reveals love not as a moment, but as commitment in action.

Lynn Hill embodies breakthrough vision, precision, and fearless mastery. Widely regarded as one of the greatest climbers in history, she is best known for her groundbreaking ascent of The Nose on El Capitan, becoming the first

person to free climb it and later completing it in under 24 hours. Her experience reflects the deep emotional and symbolic connection climbers can have with a line. A moment of meaning, vision, and love can ignite energy, courage, and commitment:

"I glanced out across the valley... and saw again the familiar heart-shaped shadow..."²⁰

This symbol of love became more than just a visual—it was a source of energy, intention, and belief. It reinforced her connection to the climb and reignited her motivation.

John Long, one of the original Stonemasters, represents the deep, authentic love of climbing rooted in experience, community, and movement. Both climber and storyteller, he has helped shape how generations understand and feel the sport:

"I felt like the sport was made for me — I loved the people, the outdoors, and I loved the movement. It was exciting, fun—and it just took off from there."²¹

For John, climbing is not just an activity—it is belonging. A way of life shaped by shared experience, adventure, and a deep connection to movement, nature, and community.

French mountaineer and climbing icon Catherine Destivelle puts it simply:

"I went climbing yesterday and the day before. I still love it."²²

For Catherine, love is not intensity alone—it is consistency. A quiet, lasting devotion that remains unchanged through time, experience, and evolution.

Chris Sharma embodies the art of climbing as flow and expression, blending visionary first ascents with a deep connection to movement, nature, and the pursuit of beautiful, powerful lines. Sharma's words capture love's continuity as inspiration:

"I just want to ride this wave as far as I can and share it with other people. Exploring these places keeps me inspired. I still want to climb. It's what makes me happy."²³

Love not only motivates—it clarifies. As John Lennon said:

"Life becomes much clearer when you love."²⁴

At its core, optimal climbing performance comes back to love—joy, challenge, resilience, and focused effort. When energy flows freely, performance becomes powerful.

Janja embodies this love-driven performance:

"I always give 100% and most importantly I love what I'm doing!"²⁵

Her immersion in the present

moment is complete:

"When I'm on the wall nothing else matters."²⁶

Love, in climbing, is not just a feeling. It is a drive — a force that sustains volition, focuses intention, and powers the flow of breath and movement. When effort is driven by love, breathing tends to remain more efficient—even at higher intensities—helping delay fatigue.

Love is a natural high. Love is the highest energy there is. Love is blind to effort, pain, or fear. Love is addictive.

Love provides a buffer to stress, anxiety, and fear:

"Love activates specific regions in the reward system. The effects include a reduction in emotional judgment and reduced fear and also reduced depression and enhanced mood."²⁷

Helen Fisher, a biological anthropologist, and neuroscientist Dr. Lucy L. Brown explore the connection between love and fearlessness:

"The amygdala is strongly associated with feelings of fear and anger. Is this why lovers so often seem fearless regardless of any obstacles they face?"²⁸

A decrease in amygdala activity suggests a lessening of fear. Love decreases amygdala activity.

Adam Ondra says:

"Climbing is a joy. I love it. No matter how hard I try or how much it hurts, it is hard to imagine life without this vertical movement."²⁹

Research shows that as climbing ability increases, so does the emotional connection and need to climb:

"reported a strong, overarching need to participate in climbing."³⁰

Climbing is addictive.

Dopamine (DA) is released when we do things we enjoy or love

Climbing is not only physical.

It is neurological, emotional, and deeply motivational.

Why do climbers willingly endure fear, uncertainty, pain, fatigue, repeated failure, and extreme physical effort — only to return to a project again and again? Part of the answer lies in dopamine.

Dopamine is a powerful neuromodulator that shifts our energy levels and mindset, influencing whether we believe we can achieve something or not. It directly affects motivation, drive, attention, and our willingness to endure stress, pain, and effort in pursuit of goals. It helps determine how strongly we engage with life,

effort, challenge, and possibility.

Dopamine leans towards positive outcomes, helps regulate movement, learning, attention, and emotional responses:

“Dopamine plays an essential role in humans for the coordination of body movements, motivation, and reward.”³¹

There are two dopamine pathways.

The Nigrostriatal Pathway is mainly focused on movement, while the Mesolimbic and Mesocortical Pathways on motivation, drive, positive reinforcement and craving.

D1 receptors are primarily excitatory and more involved in reward and motivation (Mesolimbic/ Mesocortical). D2 receptors are primarily inhibitory and critical for motor control (Nigrostriatal) but also modulate dopamine signaling in reward pathways. Both receptor types work together in these pathways to maintain balance and optimize their respective functions.

Performance depends on balance between these systems.

It is well studied when it comes to action and addiction. It increases in response to any type of reward or expected reward, which provokes feelings of enjoyment and reinforcement. The brain's dopamine system is stimulated by chocolate, sex, drugs such as cocaine or

tobacco, foods high in tyrosine such as avocado or banana pulp, exercise (the more you enjoy it the higher the dopamine), swimming in cold water, and breathwork. It's linked to enhanced performance:

“Increased dopaminergic and noradrenergic activity in the brain has been associated with feelings of motivation, arousal and reward and decreased fatigue, and this has been linked to enhanced performance.”³²

For climbers, dopamine is not just about feeling good after a send. It influences the willingness to try again, tolerate discomfort, stay focused under pressure, and continue moving toward a goal despite fear, fatigue, uncertainty, or failure.

It is more accurately a molecule of motivation, anticipation, drive, and action.

The anticipation of success itself can increase dopamine activity.

The possibility of the send.
The possibility of flow.
The possibility of mastery.

Dopamine fuels feelings of optimism. This is well studied and is referred to as optimism bias. It is explained as:

“the tendency to underestimate the likelihood of negative events and overestimate the likelihood of positive events.”³³

Most climbers experience this bias, which drives them to persist in challenging projects, even after repeated failure. It's this belief that motivates climbers to keep trying, knowing that the next attempt could be the one where they succeed. Dopamine also plays a significant role in the resilience to failure. This relationship may be one reason climbers willingly spend years projecting a single route or boulder.

We have to fail in order to succeed

Each attempt carries a physiological cost — energy, focus, and breath — all of which must be managed over time.

In 2007, Tommy Caldwell began his obsession with the Dawn Wall, working the pitches and searching for a way to free climb what seemed impossible. In 2009, Kevin Jorgeson joined him. Seven years later, in December 2014, after nineteen days climbing and sleeping on the wall, they topped out.

The love of climbing becomes an addiction — one rooted as much in the process as in the outcome. The journey itself becomes deeply rewarding:

“In January of 2015, after seven years of failure, Kevin Jorgeson and I finally topped out the Dawn Wall.”³⁴

Climbers repeatedly show their willingness to dedicate years to

perfecting a single project. The BMC reports on Emma Twyford's three-year battle to send The Big Bang (9a):

“When Emma Twyford powered, crimped and screamed her way to the top of The Big Bang at Lower Pen Trwyn, she ended a three-year battle and entered British climbing's history books as the first British woman to break the 9a barrier.”³⁵

Alex Megos spent around 60 days over three years projecting
Bibliographie:

“With approximately 60 climbing days over the past three years “Bibliographie” has been by far my longest project to date.”³⁶

Martin Keller's long-term dedication to projects like Highlander (V14), Ninja Skills Sit (V15/16), and Dreamtime—with timeframes ranging from several years to over a decade—demonstrates the deep love climbers can have for a climb or boulder. Keller:

“.....made the first ascent of Highlander (V14) after some 13 years of effort. In 2019 he made the first ascent of Ninja Skills Sit (V15/16) after more than 150 sessions over three years. In 2021 he sent Dreamtime after hundreds of days over 18 years.”³⁷

Nalle Hukkataival sent a Burden of Dreams V17, in 2016, after an estimated 4000 attempts!

In March 2021, Daniel Woods topped out on Return of the Sleepwalker (V17)—the culmination of an intense three-month journey. He fully immersed himself in the process:

“I put myself in isolation to really get into my head, and just be away from everything, be in the desert, review footage, get psyched, and just get raw with it. For the final 20 days, I camped 20 minutes away from the climb and went full crazy mode.”³⁸

And of the line:

“Wow, this is one of the more beautiful lines I’ve ever seen. The movement’s insane on it. The hold selection is perfect. Honestly, it’s just really fun to climb on.”³⁹

It took him seven days to stick the sloper. That breakthrough released a surge of motivation and confidence—the neurochemical reward that fuels persistence.

We spend days, months, even years repeating moves despite frustration, doubt, pain, fear, injury, and effort. We choose to love despite difficulty.

Svana Bjarnason reflects this after sending Fish Eye (8c/5.14b):

“Projecting this route made me learn so much about myself. It has brought me very low downs, but the highest ups. It taught me I do have strengths: a strong determination and resilience.”⁴⁰

This pattern repeats across

generations of climbers. Tim Emmett spent eight years projecting Era Vella — a 45-metre overhanging route in Margalef — investing around 130 days before finally sending in November 2025. The experience pushed him to his limits:

“That is the interesting thing about Era Vella. I’ve never cried on any route ever in 35 years of climbing. But Era Vella has brought me to tears multiple times.”⁴¹

Love is a conscious choice. Love is the addiction.

Wim Hof describes love as a powerful force within the brain:

“Love activates the deeper parts of your brain and enables you not to think but to fly, to feel vulnerably.”⁴²

The love of climbing is not just enjoyment—it is a powerful, almost addictive force that keeps climbers returning, again and again, despite the struggle.

Anna Hazelnutt captures the essence of persistence:

“Even if it seems like there’s no way you’ll ever do it, that can change within a single session. “It’s happened so many times before where the impossible becomes possible,” Anna says. So you should try things that feel hard – really hard.”⁴³

This phenomenon — sudden progress after repeated failure — is

part of what makes climbing so deeply rewarding.

Set a clear goal. Love the struggle

Set a clear goal — or choose a project — to create an external focus. Feel psyched. Love the struggle.

Our energy flows to what we pay attention to:

“Based on the OPTIMAL theory, adopting an external focus of attention reduces self-focus, directs attention to the task goals, and connects goals and actions.”⁴⁴

For Svana Bjarnason, her goal of sending Fish Eye (8c/5.14b) became an anchor through moments of doubt. She explains:

“I doubted myself a hundred times these past years—my goals, my life choices, my decisions. But deep down I never stopped believing in Fish Eye.”⁴⁵

Her unwavering belief in the project fueled her determination and resilience. By making Fish Eye her external focus, Svana found the motivation to overcome internal challenges and succeed.

Jerry Moffatt says that when you love climbing and have a goal, you enjoy the process — and then it is not so hard:

“I love training, I love climbing... so it’s not hard if you enjoy it. If you don’t have a goal, anything to wake up and train for it would be very hard.”⁴⁶

A project — a goal, a dream — that we love and put our heart into provides meaning, direction, and an external focus. That does not mean it is easy.

Arnaud Petit reflects on the deeper significance of a project:

“the project provides meaning to my life and becomes the most important thing, as if it had always existed.”⁴⁷

For Adam Ondra, long-term vision becomes reality through intention and persistence. In 2018, he achieved the first 9a+ flash with Super Crackinette:

“I had a dream of flashing 9a+ since I was 18.”⁴⁸

And in that moment:

“nothing could really stop me. It just kept going. And, the dream was done.”⁴⁹

When we have a clear goal — an external focus — it becomes easier to stay present and commit to the process. Goals direct attention, simplify decision-making, and align thought with action:

“Goals allow people to concentrate attention on the task at hand.”⁵⁰

An optimal experience is a state of flow

An optimal experience is a state of flow.

It is autotelic — immersed in immediate experience, acting with total involvement. We feel a deep sense of enjoyment, exhilaration, acceptance, and connectedness to ourselves, to movement, and to nature.

Everything comes together as it is meant to be.
It could not be any different.
There is no resistance.
There is no judgement.

Daniel Woods describes this on the day of sending Return of the Sleepwalker:

“Pure zone state was entered. My breathing was on point. My flow was on point. My body didn’t hurt. Nothing felt hard. Everything was feeling good.”⁵²

In these moments, breathing becomes steady, rhythmic, and deeply connected to movement — a pattern often seen when climbers are operating close to their limit, yet still in control.

Tommy Caldwell captures the same total absorption:

“Nothing else exists but that hold, that sequence of moves over stone, the information being sent

from fingertips to brain.”⁵²

Attention narrows, movement simplifies, and breathing aligns with action.

Janja expresses the essence of presence:

“I can say that I was enjoying every second in the finals, not thinking about the outcome but just enjoying the present.”⁵³

The psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi defines it simply:

“The key element of an optimal experience is that it is an end in itself.”⁵⁴

Flow is intrinsically rewarding.
It is complete in itself.
It is being fully present.

Breathing, in this state, is often quiet, efficient, and precisely matched to effort.

Alex Honnold describes this state of pure action:

“I’m not thinking about anything. I’m just doing the activity itself... you’re totally lost in what you’re doing and you’re just doing it.”⁵⁵

When a climber is fully engaged, breathing often settles into a more efficient rhythm. Effort feels sustainable, movement flows, and the body works as a unified system. In contrast, fear or resistance can disrupt this rhythm—breathing

becomes faster, more erratic, and fatigue arrives sooner.

Love climbing. Have fun

Alex Lowe, one of the best climbers the world has seen, was known for saying:

“The best climber in the world is the one having the most fun.”⁵⁶

Lonnie Kauk echoes this:

“Always be yourself, have fun, enjoy the journey and put your heart and soul into everything you do, it will shine.”⁵⁷

Michaela Kiersch, after sending Dreamcatcher (9a), shares:

“I decided to just have fun and go for it.”⁵⁸

Positivity is not just a feeling—it is a performance tool. Research shows:

“In a meta-analysis of nearly 300 empirical studies on positive affect, researchers found that positivity is not only related to success in life, but also predicts it.”⁵⁹

Alex Megos reframes effort as opportunity:

“I try to stay in a positive mood and that helps a lot. I treat each climb as a challenge and not as a burden.”⁶⁰

In 2022 Seb Bouin completed his project DNA 9c in Verdon. It was the

second 9c in the world. Bouin says to Black Diamond:

“I needed a line that would motivate me to go back again and again, something beautiful, impressive, in an inspiring location.”⁶¹

He spent 150 days on it. In the beginning he says:

“The first few tries were laborious. I didn’t understand anything. It seemed too big, too hard, too desperate.”⁶²

Seb’s advice for sending your project is:

“Smile and go for it!”⁶³

The act of a genuine big smile releases the feel-good neurotransmitters:

“dopamine, endorphins and serotonin are all released when a smile flashes across your face as well.”⁶⁴

Find a project you love

Love is a motivation system. Paige Claassan says:

“Pick routes you love.”⁶⁵

Positive emotions broaden attention, reduce anxiety, and increase resilience, grit, and self-belief:

“In the field of sport, positivity has been linked to optimal functioning, showing relationships with

self-esteem, self-efficacy or resilience.”⁶⁶

For many climbers, inspiration comes from the beauty of the line itself.

Matt Bush explains:

“my focus changes with my feelings and motivation. Sometimes I am really inspired by a beautiful boulder or a sport climb.”⁶⁷

Why climbers love climbing

The combination of movement, focus, breathing, exploration, risk, uncertainty, reward, and emotional intensity creates a uniquely powerful neurological experience.

Climbing simultaneously engages the motor system, vestibular system, proprioceptive system, emotional centres, attentional networks, reward pathways, autonomic and respiratory control systems, cardiovascular and endocrine systems, and the muscular-fascial networks that coordinate movement, posture, and force.

This may help explain why climbing often feels deeply immersive, emotionally meaningful, psychologically regulating, and profoundly alive.

It may also explain why climbing can become therapeutic, transformational, addictive, and life-affirming.

The breath sits at the centre of this experience.

The Pranaclimb Perspective

Ultimately, peak performance comes back to love — joy, challenge, resilience, and focused effort. When energy flows freely, movement and performance become powerful. Breathing becomes more efficient, supporting sustained effort and control. When attention is present, flow emerges. Breath is the bridge between mind, body, and movement.

By training your breathing, you deepen your connection to movement, regulate your energy, and create the conditions for flow — on the wall and in life. It becomes both a tool for awareness and a strategy for performance.

Breath is life. Train it — and you climb stronger, longer, and higher. Breath is always there — shaping how we feel, move, and climb.

Key Takeaways — Love, Breathe, Climb

Love is the foundation

Love is not just a feeling—it is a drive. It fuels motivation, sustains effort, and gives meaning to the climb.

Intention directs performance

Your mental state is powerful when it is directed outward—toward a goal, a movement, a line. What you focus on shapes your experience and

your outcome.

Emotion is energy in motion

Emotions are not obstacles—they are energy. When understood and accepted, they enhance performance rather than limit it.

Breath is the bridge

Breathing connects mind and body. It regulates emotion, sharpens attention, and supports efficient movement under pressure.

Dopamine drives persistence

Enjoyment, reward, and belief fuel motivation. This is why climbers return again and again—despite failure, effort, and time.

Love the process

Progress in climbing takes time—days, months, even years. Resilience is built through repetition, failure, and continued commitment.

Goals create direction

A meaningful project provides focus, structure, and purpose. External focus improves performance and reduces distraction.

Flow is the optimal state

Flow emerges when love, focus, and breathing align. It is effortless, immersive, and intrinsically rewarding.

Positivity enhances performance

Enjoyment, curiosity, and a positive mindset broaden attention, reduce anxiety, and improve outcomes.

You can train this

Love, breathing, attention, and emotional regulation are trainable skills.

The Pranaclimb Mantra

Love what you do.

Breathe with awareness.

Climb with intention.

This is Pranaclimb.